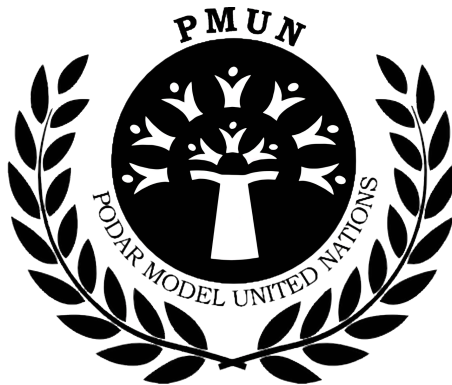




PMUN

BACKGROUND GUIDE - 5

Topic: Addressing Challenges to Women's Rights and Empowerment

Committee: United Nations Entity for Gender Equality and the Empowerment of Women (UN Women)



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A. Understanding the Issue

Women's rights are human rights that ensure equality, dignity, and freedom for women and girls in all spheres of life—social, economic, and political.

Despite progress over the past decades, gender inequality persists due to deeply rooted structural and cultural barriers.

Key challenges include:



Limited access to quality education, particularly in rural and conflict-affected areas



Workplace discrimination, including wage gaps and a lack of leadership opportunities



Gender-based violence (GBV), including domestic violence, trafficking, and early marriage



Underrepresentation in governance and decision-making bodies

These challenges are often reinforced by intersecting factors such as poverty, conflict, and discriminatory laws. As a result, women's empowerment is not only a rights issue but also a development and justice concern.

B. Why is it important globally?

Gender equality is central to global development and is explicitly recognised in Sustainable Development Goal 5. Empowering women has a multiplier effect across societies.



Economic Growth: According to the World Bank, increasing women's participation in the workforce can significantly boost GDP.



Social Development: Educated women contribute to improved health, education, and well-being of families.



Governance: Greater female participation leads to more inclusive and effective policymaking.



Peace and Security: Evidence shows that involving women in peace processes increases the likelihood of lasting peace agreements.

Therefore, addressing gender inequality is essential not only for fairness but for sustainable global progress.

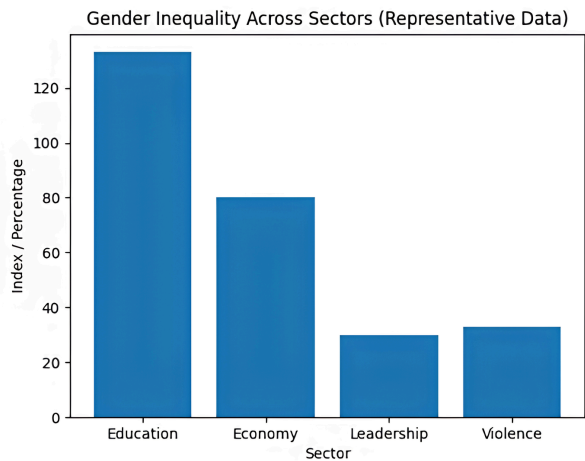
C. Key Statistics & Graphs

- Women earn approximately 20% less than men globally (UN Women, 2024).
- 133 million girls are out of school worldwide (UNESCO, 2023).
- 1 in 3 women experience physical or sexual violence (WHO/UN Women).
- Women perform three times more unpaid domestic work than men (UNDP).
- Women hold only 30% of leadership positions globally (ILO/UN Women).
- It may take over 130 years to achieve full gender equality (World Economic Forum, 2024).

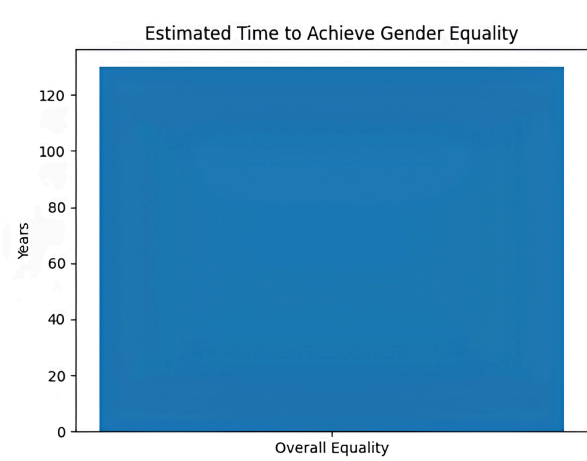
These statistics highlight that gender inequality is widespread and deeply embedded across multiple sectors.

Graphs

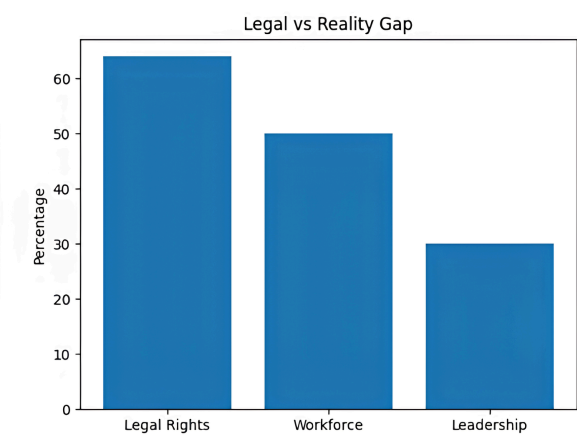
Graph 1: Inequality Across Sectors



Graph 2: Time to Achieve Gender Equality



Graph 3: Legal vs Reality Gap



D. Learn About Your Committee - UN Women

1. What Does Your Committee Do?

- Promotes gender equality and women’s empowerment globally
- Supports countries in creating laws, policies, and programs for women’s rights
- Raises awareness through global campaigns (e.g., gender equality initiatives)
- Provides research, data, and funding support to improve women’s conditions
- Works with governments and organisations to reduce discrimination and violence

Check Powers & Limitations of the Committee

POWERS	LIMITATIONS
• Can recommend policies and frameworks for gender equality • Can support countries with expertise, funding, and data • Can influence global discussions and priorities • Can coordinate international efforts on women’s rights	• Cannot enforce laws directly in any country • Depends on member states for implementation • Relies on voluntary funding and cooperation • Has limited authority in conflict zones without government support

Past Actions of the Committee

- Supported laws and policies to reduce gender-based violence
- Promoted women's participation in politics and leadership
- Led global campaigns like HeForShe
- Contributed to the development and implementation of SDG 5 (Gender Equality)
- Provided support for education, economic empowerment, and legal reforms for women
- Worked on peace and security initiatives involving women

Sources



UN Women Official Website	United Nations (UN) Gender Equality Portal	UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDG 5)	Background Guide provided
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E. UN Actions and Frameworks

The United Nations has played a central role in promoting gender equality through international agreements and institutional mechanisms.

I. Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW, 1979)

CEDAW is the primary international legal framework for women's rights and is often referred to as the international bill of rights for women. Countries that ratify it are legally obligated to eliminate discrimination in areas such as education, employment, healthcare, and political participation.

Key Features:

1. Defines discrimination broadly (not just legal, but also social and cultural)
2. Requires countries to submit periodic reports to a monitoring committee
3. Encourages temporary special measures (like quotas) to accelerate equality.

Limitations:

1. Some countries have entered reservations (exceptions), weakening its impact
2. Enforcement depends on national implementation, not global policing
3. Insight: Delegates can question whether international law without enforcement is effective.

II. Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action (1995)

Adopted at the Fourth World Conference on Women, this is one of the most comprehensive global policy frameworks for gender equality.

Key Areas (12 Critical Areas of Concern):



Poverty



Education



Health



Violence against women



Women in power and decision-making



Media representation



Environment

Why it matters:

1. Shifted focus from “women as beneficiaries” to “women as agents of change”
2. Encouraged governments to create national action plans

Limitations:



1. It is not legally binding
2. Progress varies significantly across regions.

Insight: Strong for policy direction, weak for accountability.

III. Sustainable Development Goal 5 (SDG 5)

Part of the 2030 Agenda, SDG 5 aims to “achieve gender equality and empower all women and girls.”

Key Targets:



1. End all forms of discrimination and violence
2. Eliminate harmful practices (child marriage, FGM)
3. Ensure equal participation in leadership
4. Provide access to reproductive health and rights

Why it matters:

1. Integrates gender equality into global development planning
2. Linked with other SDGs (poverty, education, health)

Challenges:

1. Progress is uneven and slow
2. Many countries lack data and accountability systems
3. Insight: Delegates can debate whether SDGs are too ambitious vs not ambitious enough.

IV. UN Women

Established in 2010, UN Women is the UN’s primary agency dedicated to gender equality.

Core Functions:

1. Supports countries in creating laws and policies
2. Runs global campaigns (e.g., HeForShe)
3. Provides data, research, and funding programs

Impact:

1. Helped expand laws on domestic violence in multiple countries
2. Supports women’s participation in politics and peace processes

Limitations:

1. Relies heavily on voluntary funding
2. Limited power to enforce change

V. United Nations Development Programme (UNDP)

UNDP integrates gender equality into broader development goals like poverty reduction and governance.

Key Contributions:

1. Publishes the Gender Inequality Index (GII)
2. Supports women's economic empowerment programs
3. Works on legal reforms and institutional capacity-building

Approach: Focuses on long-term structural change, not just immediate relief

Challenges:

1. Impact depends on government cooperation
2. Results vary across regions

VI. UN Security Council Resolution 1325 (2000)

This landmark resolution focuses on Women, Peace, and Security (WPS).

Key Pillars:

1. Participation: Women in peace negotiations
2. Protection: From sexual violence in conflict
3. Prevention: Address root causes of conflict
4. Relief & Recovery: Gender-sensitive post-conflict rebuilding

Why it matters:

1. Recognises that conflict affects women differently
2. Pushes for inclusion of women in peacebuilding processes

Challenges:

1. Women still make up a small percentage of peace negotiators
2. Implementation is inconsistent

F. Case Studies

1. India – Education Initiatives:

The Beti Bachao Beti Padhao scheme aims to address the declining child sex ratio and promote girls' education. While enrolment has improved, regional disparities remain.

Source: <https://wcd.nic.in/bbbp-scheme>

2. Saudi Arabia – Legal Reforms:

Reforms allowing women to drive and work have increased economic participation, but structural limitations still exist.

Source: <https://www.weforum.org/agenda/2018/10/saudi-arabia-women-driving-ban-end/>

3. Sub-Saharan Africa – Education Barriers:

Girls face barriers such as poverty and early marriage, limiting access to education.

Source: <https://www.unicef.org/education/girls-education>

4. Mexico – Gender-Based Violence:

Despite strong laws against femicide, enforcement challenges persist.

5. Conflict Zones:

Women in conflict areas face increased violence and lack access to basic services.

Source: <https://www.unwomen.org/en/what-we-do/peace-and-security>

Key Discussion Questions and Points

1. What are women's rights? Why are they considered human rights?
2. What does gender equality actually look like in daily life?

Major Challenges Faced by Women -

- Access to education (especially in rural/conflict areas)
- Workplace inequality (pay gap, leadership roles)
- Gender-based violence (domestic violence, trafficking, early marriage)
- Underrepresentation in politics and decision-making

Root Causes of Inequality

- Cultural norms and stereotypes
- Poverty and lack of resources
- Weak laws or poor implementation
- Conflict and instability

Why Gender Equality Matters Globally

- Economic benefits (GDP growth, workforce participation)
- Social impact (health, education of families)
- Governance (better decision-making)
- Peace and security (role of women in peace processes)

Role of Global Organisations

- What is the purpose of frameworks like CEDAW, SDG 5?
- Why is implementation often weak despite strong policies?

G. List of Agendas

Rights vs Reality

"Laws for women's rights exist, but they are not effectively implemented."

"Legal reforms alone are not enough to achieve gender equality."

Education & Empowerment

"Education is the most powerful tool for women's empowerment."

"Governments should prioritise girls' education over other development goals."

Workplace Equality

"Equal pay policies should be strictly enforced worldwide."

"Women face more barriers than men in leadership roles."

Cultural vs Structural Change

"Changing mindsets is more important than changing laws."

"Cultural traditions are the biggest barrier to gender equality."

Global Responsibility

"Achieving gender equality should be a global responsibility, not just national."

"International organisations like the UN are effective in promoting women's rights."

Representation & Leadership

"Countries should introduce quotas for women in politics."

"Women leaders create more inclusive societies."

Safety & Justice

"Stronger punishments are the best way to reduce gender-based violence."

"Awareness and education are more effective than laws in preventing violence."

H. References & Recommended Reading

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